
AN ILLUSTRATED FAIRY-TALE NOVEL
Princess
AL ZAHRAA
in Wonderland
A brave heart. A loving home.
Growing in confidence and love of Allah

Made for you, Al Zahraa

With all our love, Baba & Mama

For your wonderful, curious heart and all the years of learning ahead.

Enjoy the pictures and short passages together now. As you grow, return to the full story and its thoughtful chapter challenges. Talk, draw, or write; you do not need to answer every question at once.

Wonderland is an imagined dream adventure. The love that inspired it comes from your family letter.



Our precious Al Zahraa

We love you simply because you are our beloved daughter. You never have to earn our love, prove your worth, or give us anything in return.

From the first moment we held you, you made a home in our hearts. We love your laughter, your curiosity, and the little ways you make each day your own.

On joyful days and difficult days, when you feel brave and when you need to be held, our love will stay. You will always have a place in our arms.

Grow strong, trust your voice, and be gentle with yourself. You are incomparable; you do not need to be anyone else. May your own view of yourself be rooted in kindness and confidence.

We wish you a heart at peace, a life filled with love, and happiness that stays with you. Wherever life takes you, you will always be our cherished girl.

All our love, always,

Baba & Mama

Inside Wonderland

Ten chapters of courage, faith, and love

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AFTER EVERY CHAPTER

One full challenge page: notice, think deeper, try another view, create, and live the lesson.

The Door Beyond the Roses

On the evening the adventure began, Al Zahraa wore purple pyjamas with smiling rabbits on them. Her pink birthday dress hung beside the wardrobe, and a little star lamp warmed the room. Mama sat close enough for their shoulders to touch. Baba held a letter with a rose-coloured border. Outside, the last light lay across Salalah like a soft ribbon.



"Read the part about the arms," Al Zahraa asked.

Baba smiled. "You will always have a place in our arms."

She tucked those words inside her heart, where the most important things belonged.

Later, with her cheek against her pillow, Al Zahraa wondered what it would be like to be a princess. Would she have to know every answer? Would she have to smile when she felt sad? Perhaps real princesses never spilled their milk or needed help with a difficult button.

"You can be yourself," Mama had told her. "We love you on all your days."



Al Zahraa whispered a little prayer in her own words. "Allah, thank You for Mama and Baba. Help me be kind and brave tomorrow."

Sleep came gently. In her dream, the bedroom curtains became waterfalls of purple flowers. The star lamp became a lantern beside a garden door. Her pyjamas became the pink dress from her birthday picture, with soft flowers at the shoulders and a skirt that rustled like leaves. Her shoes were comfortable, which seemed an excellent thing for a princess's shoes to be.

Beyond the door stood a castle with rose-coloured towers. A path curved towards it through a thousand blossoms. At the gate, a white rabbit wrestled with a satchel much too large for him.

"Oh, good," he said when he saw her. "Someone with hands."

He was trying to fold a map. Every time he folded one side, another sprang open.

Al Zahraa laughed. It was a small laugh, but it loosened the worry she had brought from her pillow.

Together they folded the map badly, then better. The rabbit introduced himself as Nuri, keeper of the garden messages.

"Welcome to Wonderland, Princess Al Zahraa."



She looked behind her. "How do you know I am a princess?"

"Your invitation says so." He pulled out a card decorated with roses. On it were her name and a simple welcome. There was no test at the bottom.

"Do I have to do something wonderful first?"

"You have to come through the gate if you would like to visit. That is the whole arrangement."

This was encouraging. Al Zahraa stepped into a garden that smelled of rain and orange blossom. Yet something was wrong. The stone channel beside the path was dry. A tiny waterwheel stood still. Flowers leaned towards empty watering bowls.

Nuri's ears drooped. "Last night's wind damaged the upper channel. Water cannot reach the Garden of First Light. Tomorrow is our gathering, and everyone has been working so hard."

"Can I mend it?" Al Zahraa asked immediately.

"I don't know," said Nuri. "I certainly cannot mend it alone. First we must find Safiya, the gardener, and understand what happened."

Al Zahraa liked that he did not pretend to know everything. She looked at the thirsty flowers. She could not promise a whole garden, but she could carry a message.

They found Safiya beside a rosebush, pouring the last water from a small jug around its roots. Her lavender scarf was dotted with petals. She greeted Al Zahraa as though she had been expected all along.

"What would help?" the princess asked.

Safiya pointed to a shaded bench. "First, sit with me. You have travelled, and I have forgotten to rest."

This was not what Al Zahraa expected grown-ups to say during an emergency. They drank cool water from a covered pitcher. Nuri ate a piece of pear with great concentration.

Then Safiya unfolded the map. Water normally flowed from a hill reservoir, past a footbridge and an old workshop, through a gate in the Lantern Tower, and into the garden. The wind had damaged several places along the route. Nobody yet knew which repairs mattered most.

"Maryam is helping us make a plan," Safiya said. "She is in the courtyard. Will you and Nuri take her this map? Stay together. Ask the grown-ups before going near damaged places."

Al Zahraa nodded, then hesitated. "What if I am too little to be useful?"

Safiya set down her jug. "Little people can notice important things. You are also welcome here when you are resting. Helping is something we share; it is not the price of your place."

The princess touched the ribbon on her bag. A folded letter was inside.

Al Zahraa took out the letter. It was Baba and Mama's letter, the one with the rose-coloured border. Dreams, she decided, were very good at packing.



She read the line she remembered best: "You never have to earn our love, prove your worth, or give us anything in return."

The words made room inside her chest. She had thought courage might feel like becoming enormous. Instead, it felt like having enough space to breathe.

"I would like to help," she told Safiya. "And I will ask when I don't know how."

"That is a good beginning."

Nuri tucked the map safely into his satchel. Al Zahraa whispered, "Bismillah," beginning in Allah's name, and took her first step along the path.

At the courtyard entrance, she stopped beside a small seedling in a cracked pot. Its leaves had bent over the edge. She moved it out of the path so no one would tread on it, then called Safiya to check where it should go.

"We will keep that one in the shade," the gardener said. "Thank you for noticing."

It was not a grand rescue. There were no trumpets. Yet Al Zahraa felt pleased.

Ahead, tall mirrors flashed between rose-covered pillars. Beyond them, someone was singing while a hammer tapped a steady rhythm. She squeezed the letter once through her bag and followed the sound.

Your Wonderland Challenge

Talk, draw, or write. Take your time.

I am loved before my adventure begins.

1 NOTICE

Why does Al Zahraa initially think she might be too little to help? Find something Safiya says that changes her thinking.

2 THINK DEEPER

If the garden is never repaired, would Al Zahraa still deserve a welcome? Explain using a moment from the chapter.

3 TRY ANOTHER VIEW

What does Nuri do when he does not know the answer? Why might this make him a trustworthy companion?

4 CREATE

Draw a welcome card with no competition, test, or condition on it. What would you write inside?

5 LIVE IT

Name one small helpful action you can take with an adult today. Make a short personal dua for kindness.

The Garden of Mirrors



The courtyard held mirrors of every shape: oval mirrors, round mirrors, one shaped like a pear. Some made Nuri look as tall as a tower. Others gave Al Zahraa shoes the size of rowing boats. She laughed until she reached a perfectly ordinary mirror. In it, she saw another girl standing behind her, straight-backed and confident, with a neat lilac scarf and a tool belt full of pencils.

The girl was building a little model bridge.

Suddenly, Al Zahraa was not thinking about her funny shoes anymore.

"I am Maryam," the girl said. "Will you hold this end?"

Al Zahraa held a strip of wood while Maryam tied it to two short sticks. The model stood immediately. Al Zahraa thought of the tower she had built at home that had fallen before she could show Baba.



"You are very good at that," she said.

"Thank you. My first twelve bridges were terrible. One collapsed into my soup."

Al Zahraa smiled, but the tight feeling stayed. Maryam could build. Safiya could grow roses. Even Nuri knew all the paths. What could a little princess do except wear a pretty dress?

A breeze moved through the mirrors. In the nearest glass, Maryam's tool belt seemed brighter, while Al Zahraa's empty hands seemed smaller. The mirror had not changed; she was only looking at herself more harshly.

"Do you have a tool belt for me?" she asked.

"We can find one," Maryam replied. "What do you need to carry?"

Al Zahraa did not know. She wanted the belt because Maryam had one. The answer was uncomfortable, so she looked down at the map instead.

There, beneath Nuri's paw, she noticed a thin blue line almost hidden by a fold. It branched away from the broken footbridge.

"What is that path?" she asked.

Maryam leaned closer. "I thought it was a crease."

Nuri fetched a smooth stone to hold the paper flat. The blue line led towards an orchard and returned near the workshop. Beside it was a tiny drawing of a water bucket.

"An old service lane," Maryam said. "Perhaps the gardeners used it before the footbridge was built. We should ask someone who knows."

Al Zahraa felt a spark of pleasure. Then she caught herself wanting to ask whether she was better at maps than Maryam.

"I noticed something you missed," she said instead, surprised by how sharp the words sounded.

Maryam looked up. "You did. Now our plan is better."

There was no hurt in her voice and no contest in her smile. Al Zahraa's cheeks warmed.

"I wanted to be good at something," she admitted.

"You are allowed to want that," Maryam said. "But you don't have to make me smaller to make room for yourself."

They sat on the low wall. Maryam explained that she loved making models but often lost track of what people were saying while she worked. Nuri remembered every delivery address but sometimes mixed up left and right. Al Zahraa noticed little things and asked questions.

None of them had every skill. Together, they had more than any one of them could carry.

At the far end of the courtyard, a gardener was sorting seed packets. His hands shook slightly, so Maryam offered to steady the tray. Al Zahraa held the packets while Nuri read the labels.

The gardener knew the blue line on the map. "The orchard lane is still there," he said. "But check with Hamid at the footbridge before choosing your route. The rain changes the ground."



He gave them a small notebook to record what they found. Al Zahraa wrote her name carefully on the first page. The letters were uneven. She nearly turned the page over.

Then she remembered the twelve bridges and the soup.

Under her name she wrote, slowly, "Things we notice."

"That is a useful title," Maryam said.

Back among the mirrors, Al Zahraa tried a different way of looking. She saw curls that would not stay perfectly neat, a pink bow leaning to one side, and a face with room for a hundred questions. She saw herself.

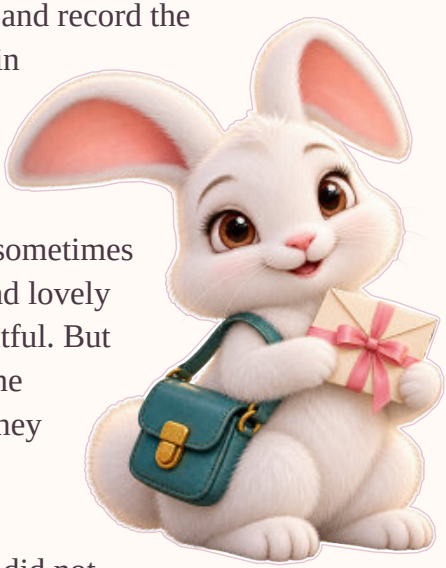
She loved the beautiful dress. She also knew that if she changed into muddy gardening clothes, the person inside would still matter.

"Allah made people different," she said softly. "I can be grateful for what I have, and I can learn what I don't know yet."

Nuri nodded. "I would like to learn how to fold that map. Properly."

Before leaving, Maryam packed the model bridge. Al Zahraa did not ask for a matching tool belt. She asked for a pencil that fitted her hand.

They planned their next steps: follow the marked path through the Whispering Wood, speak to Hamid, and record the damaged places. Safiya would remain in the garden, organizing water for the most fragile plants.



Al Zahraa turned back towards the mirrors one last time. At home, she sometimes heard people praise pretty dresses and lovely smiles. Those things could be delightful. But nobody in the courtyard had asked the roses to become sunflowers before they were allowed to grow.

"Your bridge is clever," she told Maryam. This time, the compliment did not make her own heart shrink.

"And your question found us another route," Maryam answered.

They walked side by side under the arch. Nuri tried to march grandly, stepped on the end of his satchel strap, and sat down with a surprised squeak. The girls helped him up, trying not to laugh until he laughed first.

The Whispering Wood began just beyond the roses. Its trees were tall and close together. Their leaves rubbed against one another, making a hundred small sounds.

Al Zahraa held her pencil ready. She could not build a bridge yet. She could listen, notice, and ask. For this part of the journey, that was enough to begin.

Your Wonderland Challenge

Talk, draw, or write. Take your time.

My worth does not depend on comparison.

1 NOTICE

What important detail does Al Zahraa find on the map? Why had the others overlooked it?

2 THINK DEEPER

Compare "I noticed something you missed" with "Our plan is better now." How do the two sentences affect a friendship?

3 TRY ANOTHER VIEW

Maryam admits that her early bridges failed. How does this change the way we see her skill?

4 CREATE

Draw three different flowers. Beside each, write a different strength that a person might have.

5 LIVE IT

Give someone a sincere compliment. Then name one of your own strengths without comparing it with theirs.

A Voice in the Whispering Wood



The wood was not silent. Leaves hissed, branches creaked, and a stream somewhere out of sight made a restless rushing sound. Nuri talked over all of it, describing a delivery he had once made to the wrong owl. Maryam checked the map as they walked. Al Zahraa followed between them, holding her notebook against her chest.

At a fork in the path, she saw a marker half buried in fallen leaves.

"Wait," she said.

But her voice was very small, and the wood had so many voices already.

Nuri continued to the right. Maryam followed. The marker pointed left.

Al Zahraa opened her mouth again, then closed it. Perhaps she had read the arrow incorrectly. Perhaps she would annoy them by asking another question. Her shoes stopped while the others kept moving.



"Please wait!" she called at last.

Maryam turned immediately. "What did you see?"

Al Zahraa pointed. Nuri came back, brushing leaves from the marker with his paw. Under the arrow were two pictures: a bridge and a workshop. The path on the right led to the picnic clearing.

"I was telling such an excellent story," Nuri said, "that I forgot to look where I was going."

"I tried to tell you," Al Zahraa whispered.

Maryam knelt beside her. "I'm sorry I didn't hear. You can say my name and ask me to stop. Especially if something feels wrong."

"Even if I might be mistaken?"

"Then we can check together."

They practised once. Al Zahraa said, "Maryam, please stop. I need to show you something." She felt silly, and then she felt stronger.

She did not need to shout at everyone all the time. She needed a clear sentence and companions who would make room to listen. When they started walking again, Maryam stayed beside her instead of hurrying ahead with the map.

A little farther on, they heard a sharp, repeated chirping. A young finch sat on a low branch. One loose thread from an abandoned ribbon had caught around a twig near its foot. Each flutter tightened the thread.



Al Zahraa stepped forward, wanting to free it at once. Then she stopped. The bird was frightened, and she did not know how to handle it safely.

"We need someone who knows what to do," she said.

Nuri hurried a short distance to a nearby keeper's hut while the girls waited on the path, where he could still see them. He returned with Huda, the woodland keeper. She carried a little cloth and a pair of round-ended scissors.

Huda asked them to stand back and keep quiet. With patient hands, she loosened the ribbon from the branch. The finch hopped free, tried its foot, and flew to a higher perch.

Al Zahraa let out the breath she had been holding.

"You helped by noticing and calling me," Huda told her.

The princess had wanted to be the person who did the exciting part. Instead, her important part had been knowing when to stop.

She looked up through the leaves. "Alhamdulillah," she whispered, thankful for the bird's freedom and for the keeper who had known how to help.

The finch shook its feathers, looking deeply offended by the whole morning.

Huda walked with them to the next clearing. When Al Zahraa mentioned the rushing water, the keeper frowned.

"The little stream should be gentle today. Show me where you heard it."

They stayed on the marked path while Huda examined the bank from a safe place. Fallen branches had diverted water away from the garden channel and into a hollow. It was another piece of the puzzle.

Maryam began drawing the location in the notebook. Nuri offered to carry a message back to Safiya after he had brought the children to Hamid.

Al Zahraa watched the water foaming around the branches. "I almost said nothing about the arrow," she confessed. "I didn't want to be troublesome."

"A question can prevent trouble," Huda replied. "And when you need help, you do not have to make your voice beautiful before using it."

The princess thought of times she had swallowed a sentence because other people were talking. She loved being gentle. She was learning that gentleness did not require disappearing.

She asked Huda to repeat the names of the paths, then wrote them carefully. When she did not understand one word, she asked again.

No one rolled their eyes. The trees kept whispering, and for the first time that morning, Al Zahraa did not feel she had to compete with them.

At the edge of the wood, Huda gave them a simple instruction: wait beside the blue bench until Hamid came to meet them. The damaged footbridge was beyond the gate, and no child was to cross it.



They sat together. Nuri finally finished his story about the owl, which turned out to have been asleep in the correct tree after all. The problem had been that Nuri had knocked on a knot in the trunk instead of the door.

Al Zahraa laughed, then opened the notebook. Beneath the drawing of the stream, she wrote, "I can say what I notice."

Maryam added, "We can listen carefully."

That second sentence mattered. Being heard was not only Al Zahraa's responsibility. Her friends had work to do as well.

While they waited, the princess made a quiet dua. "Allah, help me speak truthfully and listen kindly. Help me ask for help when I need it."

Soon a broad-shouldered carpenter appeared, carrying a coil of rope. His name was Hamid, and sawdust clung to his sleeves.

"You brought the map?" he asked.

Al Zahraa stood up. Her voice trembled a little, but it reached him.

"Yes. And we found something else you need to know."

She showed him the rushing stream and the fallen branches in her drawing. Hamid listened without interrupting. Then he nodded and opened the gate.

Your Wonderland Challenge

Talk, draw, or write. Take your time.

My voice deserves to be heard.

1 NOTICE

List two things Al Zahraa notices in the wood. How does each observation help the group?

2 THINK DEEPER

Why is calling the woodland keeper a brave choice, even though Al Zahraa wants to free the bird herself?

3 TRY ANOTHER VIEW

The notebook includes "We can listen carefully." Why should the listeners also take responsibility?

4 CREATE

Write or practise a clear sentence for asking a trusted adult to stop and listen to an important concern.

5 LIVE IT

Take turns speaking with someone at home. Let each person finish, then repeat the main thing you heard.

The Bridge That Would Not Hold



Hamid led them only as far as the safe viewing platform. The bridge beyond it sagged in the middle. One plank had split, and a broken branch rested across the handrail. Al Zahraa had imagined a quick repair followed by a grand crossing. Instead, the carpenter tied a bright warning ribbon across the entrance.

"No crossing today," he said.

Across the stream, the workshop chimney rose between the trees. It looked close enough to touch, yet the path to it had suddenly become much longer.

Maryam spread out the map. The orchard lane might lead around the water, but Hamid needed to check whether a supply cart could use it. He gave them a safe task at his bench: build a small model to show where the cart could turn.



Al Zahraa selected three wooden blocks and a handful of short sticks. She wanted to do this part by herself. She set the sticks over a gap between two blocks, then pushed the toy cart onto them.

The sticks rolled. The cart fell. Its tiny wooden apples scattered across the bench.

"I ruined it," she said.

"You found out that round sticks roll," Hamid replied.

But Al Zahraa had already heard a harsher voice in her own thoughts: Maryam would have known. A clever princess would have known.

She folded her arms. "I cannot build anything."

Maryam did not immediately fix the model. She sat beside her and asked, "Would you like a pause, or would you like a hint?"

"A pause."

They counted the real apples in Hamid's lunch basket while Nuri collected the wooden ones. When the tight feeling in her chest softened, Al Zahraa looked at the model again.

The sticks had rolled. That was what had happened. It was different from being a person who could never learn.

"A hint now," she said.

Hamid placed a flat strip of wood beside a round stick. "What difference do you notice?"

Al Zahraa ran a finger over both. The strip stayed still. She replaced the rolling sticks with flat strips and moved the supports closer together. This time, the cart crossed halfway before the strips tilted.

Her heart sank, but less deeply.

"It held longer," she said.

"What might make the ends steadier?" Maryam asked.

They tried a wider base. On the third attempt, the cart rolled across. Nuri applauded so enthusiastically that he knocked over a pencil pot. The sudden clatter made everyone laugh.

Al Zahraa looked from the little bridge to the broken real one. "Can we use this idea there?"

"The model helps us ask questions," Hamid explained. "A real bridge carries real people. Adults with the right skills must inspect it and choose proper materials. We will not experiment on it with our feet."

She liked his answer. It made her success feel real without making it bigger than it was.

In the notebook, she wrote three attempts and drew a circle around the last one. Then, after thinking, she drew smaller circles around the first two. They had taught her something too.

Learning had left a mess of blocks on the bench. It had also left a path forward.

Hamid studied the old lane on the map. "I know the first part," he said. "The orchard keeper can tell us about the rest. I will take you as far as her gate."

Before they left, he asked the group to help count a bundle of safe, smooth wooden pegs for later repairs. Al Zahraa counted seven, then nine, then became confused when Nuri's paw covered one.



She almost pretended the answer was ten.

Instead, she moved the pegs into pairs. "Let us start again," she said.

There were twelve. Starting over had taken less time than arguing would have.

Hamid packed the pegs and checked that the damaged bridge was securely closed. Nuri left a message with the bridge assistant for Safiya, explaining the blocked stream and the alternative route.

As they walked, Al Zahraa noticed a little tear in the ribbon on her bag. It must have caught on the bench. She held it with sudden sadness. The ribbon had looked perfect that morning.

Maryam offered a small piece of thread from her kit. Together they tied the loose end so it would not catch again.

The ribbon was no longer quite as smooth. It was still hers, and it still held.

Al Zahraa thought perhaps people could feel a little like that after a hard morning: changed, tired, and still entirely worth caring for.

The lane climbed towards the orchard. Hamid walked first, checking the ground. Maryam carried the model in a basket, and Al Zahraa carried the notebook. Nuri had finally folded the map neatly enough to close his satchel.



"I wish I had got it right the first time," the princess said after a while.

"I sometimes wish that too," Hamid replied. "But wishing does not teach my hands as much as practising does."

Al Zahraa looked down at hers. They were small hands. Today they had folded, drawn, built, rested, and tried again.

She whispered, "Allah, thank You for helping hands around me. Give me patience while I learn."

Ahead, a green gate stood open under branches heavy with leaves. Beyond it, rows of seedlings lined a wall. Some had grown tall; some barely showed above the soil.

A woman in a straw gardening hat was measuring the water left in a barrel. She looked up as Hamid called her name.

"Welcome," she said. "You have arrived just in time for a puzzle."

Al Zahraa almost sighed. Another puzzle meant another chance to be wrong.

Then she opened the notebook to a clean page. Another puzzle also meant another chance to learn something she did not know yet.

This time, she did not hide the pencil marks she had rubbed out. She simply made room beside them.

Your Wonderland Challenge

Talk, draw, or write. Take your time.

A mistake is something I can learn from.

1 NOTICE

Describe how the model changes from the first attempt to the successful attempt. What does each change solve?

2 THINK DEEPER

Why does Hamid refuse to test the idea by walking on the real bridge? How is caution part of courage?

3 TRY ANOTHER VIEW

Replace "I cannot build anything" with a kinder sentence that is still honest about the failed attempt.

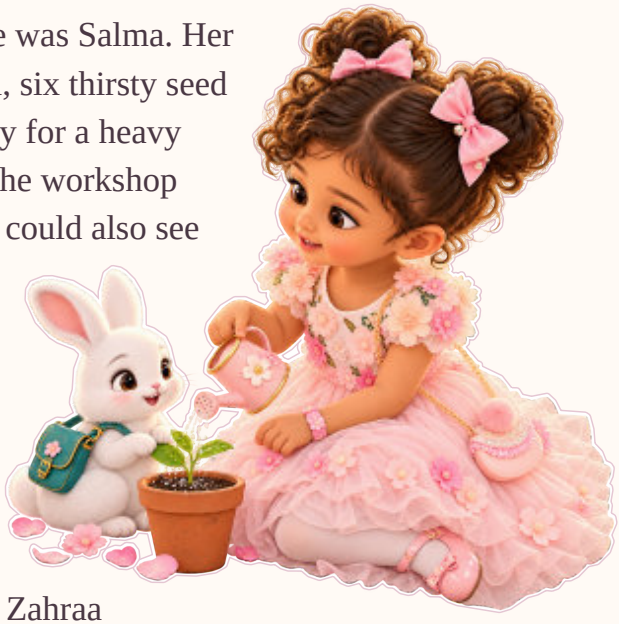
4 CREATE

With an adult, sketch two different bridges using blocks or paper. Explain what you would test before adding weight.

5 LIVE IT

Choose a small skill to practise. Notice one change between attempts, and allow yourself a break when you need one.

The Orchard of Small Beginnings



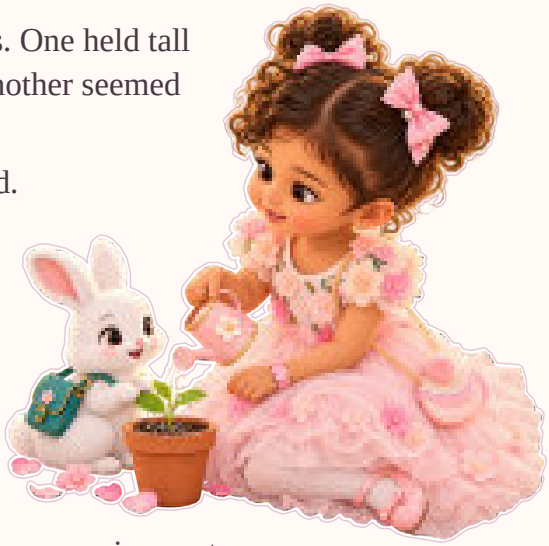
The orchard keeper's name was Salma. Her puzzle involved one barrel, six thirsty seed trays, and a lane too muddy for a heavy cart. Al Zahraa could see the workshop roof beyond the trees. She could also see that wanting to reach it quickly would not make the mud disappear.

"We need a lighter load," Salma said, "and a little time."

Time was exactly what Al Zahraa did not want to give. The garden needed water. The sky was changing. Waiting felt terribly like doing nothing.



Hamid and Salma inspected the lane while the children waited under the orchard shelter. Nuri checked the message tucked in his satchel. Maryam examined the model cart to see which supplies could be carried in smaller trips.



Al Zahraa stared at the seed trays. One held tall shoots with two proud leaves. Another seemed to contain nothing but dark soil.

"Those seeds are losing," she said.

Salma, returning from the lane, shook her head gently. "They are different plants. They do not all begin on the same day."

She showed Al Zahraa the labels. Some seeds needed more time before any green appeared. Others had already begun growing roots beneath the soil.

"But you cannot see the roots," the princess said.

"No. That is why I keep notes, give suitable care, and wait. Pulling them up to check would hurt them."

Al Zahraa thought about learning words, doing buttons, and trying the bridge model. She often wanted to see improvement immediately. If she could not see it, she assumed it was missing.

She asked whether she could help water the trays. Salma showed her how much to use, and Al Zahraa poured slowly, stopping when the soil was moist.

A tiny shoot bent under one drop, then lifted again. Al Zahraa watched it for a long moment without asking it to hurry.

The lane was passable on foot, Hamid reported, but the cart would have to wait. He could carry the repair tools in a small pack. The children could carry their own light belongings. Salma would send the remaining supplies later with another adult, once the ground had settled.



Al Zahraa looked at the sky. "What if we miss the gathering?"

"Then we will have a smaller gathering," Salma said. "Or a later one. The garden will not become less important because our plan changes."

That answer was sensible. It was also disappointing.

Al Zahraa pressed her lips together. She had imagined the flowers springing upright, the waterwheel turning, and everyone cheering before sunset. Now there was mud on her shoes and a long walk ahead.

"I wanted it to be easier," she admitted.

"So did I," said Hamid, setting down his pack.

They ate under the shelter. Al Zahraa said "Alhamdulillah" for the fruit and water, but she still felt impatient. She told Salma this, as though gratitude had failed to work.



"You can be thankful for your lunch and disappointed about the delay," Salma replied. "Both feelings can be here."

Al Zahraa took another bite. She did not have to pretend the day was perfect in order to notice something good within it.

When the adults said the lane was ready, the group set off. They walked slowly around puddles, keeping away from the soft edges. Hamid led the way with the tool pack, and Salma accompanied them to the firmer path.

At one bend, Al Zahraa saw a fallen pear lying beside a trail of ants. She stepped around them instead of through them. The ants did not know they had delayed a princess for three seconds. They carried on with their work.

"You are patient with them," Maryam observed.

"They have such tiny legs."

Maryam looked at Al Zahraa's small shoes. The princess laughed before her friend could say anything.

Perhaps she could offer herself some of the patience she gave an ant.

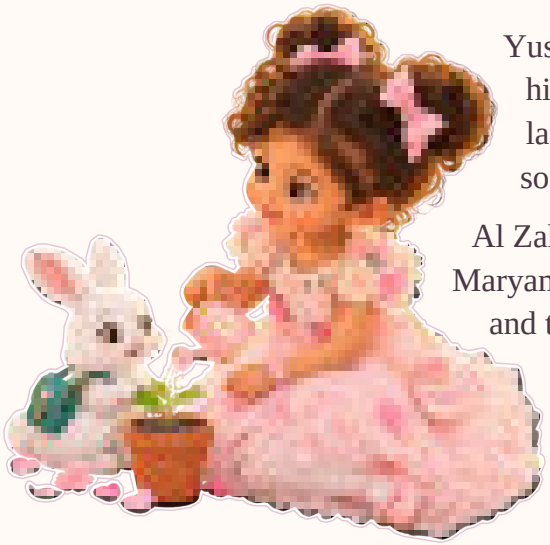
At the next resting place, Al Zahraa opened the notebook. She added a small drawing of a seed beneath the soil. Under it, she wrote, "Growing can happen before I can see it."

She asked Allah for patience, then asked Hamid how far they had left to walk. Trusting Allah did not prevent her from needing practical information. Hamid showed her the next turn and the shaded bench beyond it.

Knowing the next small step helped more than imagining the whole long journey at once.

At last, the workshop door appeared between two flowering trees, its brass handle shaped like a curling leaf.

A little bell sounded when Hamid pushed the door open. Inside, clocks ticked at different speeds. Shelves held polished wheels, wooden birds, and lantern frames waiting for glass. The room smelled of cedar and warm tea.



Yusuf, the clockmaker, rose from his bench. "You took the orchard lane," he said. "I was hoping someone remembered it."

Al Zahraa showed him the notebook. Maryam explained the broken bridge and the diverted stream. Hamid described the tools he had brought.

Yusuf listened, then laid a drawing of the Lantern Tower mechanism on the table. The tower controlled a gate in the water channel. If the gate remained closed, even a cleared stream would not refill the garden.

"We have two problems, not one," Maryam said.

"And now we understand them better," Yusuf answered.

Al Zahraa had thought the delay meant their adventure was going wrong. Yet the orchard had given them a safe route, a sensible carrying plan, and a chance to arrive together.

Before taking off her bag, she touched the folded letter inside it. She had grown tired and impatient and had not become less loved.

The thought steadied her as Yusuf brought over a tray of interesting objects. On top lay a magnifying lens with a copper handle, shining like a small, round window. Al Zahraa leaned closer to look.

Your Wonderland Challenge

Talk, draw, or write. Take your time.

I can grow at my own pace.

1 NOTICE

Why do the travellers leave the heavy cart behind? Explain how their new plan solves a problem.

2 THINK DEEPER

What does the unseen root suggest about learning? Give an example that does not involve a plant.

3 TRY ANOTHER VIEW

Can Al Zahraa be grateful and disappointed at the same time? Support your answer with the lunch scene.

4 CREATE

Draw a goal as a growing plant. Label one small action that would help its roots, even before results are visible.

5 LIVE IT

Try a patient pause today. Make a personal dua, take a calm breath, and choose one manageable next step.

The Truth in the Clockmaker's Room



Yusuf's magnifying lens made a leaf vein look like a river. It made a grain of wood look like a hill. Al Zahraa wanted to see what it would do to the tiny silver flower on her bag.

While Yusuf and Hamid discussed the tower drawing, she reached across the tray. Her sleeve brushed the copper handle. The lens slid, struck the edge of the bench, and landed with a sharp little crack.

No one spoke for a moment.

Al Zahraa wished she could fold herself as small as Nuri's map.

The lens had fallen onto a lower wooden shelf. Its glass was cracked inside the frame. Al Zahraa froze, keeping her hands away from it.

"Nobody touch the glass," Yusuf said calmly. He checked that no one was hurt and moved the lens into a safe tray.



"What happened?"

Al Zahraa could say the tray had moved. She could say she did not know. The room was crowded; perhaps no one had seen her sleeve.

Her throat tightened. She imagined Yusuf refusing to help, Hamid shaking his head, Maryam wishing she had brought someone more careful. The whole garden might suffer because of her.

Then she remembered the letter in her bag. Love did not vanish whenever something broke. Even so, the truth was difficult to lift.

"I reached for it without asking," she said. "My sleeve caught the handle. I am sorry."

Yusuf sat on the stool opposite her. His face looked disappointed, but his voice remained kind.

"Thank you for telling me. That was my favourite lens. I will need to replace the glass. Next time, ask before reaching across a workbench."

Al Zahraa blinked quickly. She had told the truth, and the lens was still broken. She had not escaped a consequence. But she no longer had to carry a secret as well.

"Can you forgive me?" she asked.

"Yes," Yusuf said. "And we will work out what repair is possible."

He explained that she should not pick up glass or attempt to mend it. He would handle that part. She could help with a safe task: sorting the large wooden labels into their matching trays.

Al Zahraa began slowly. She still felt ashamed. When a tear landed on her hand, she tried to wipe it away before anyone noticed.

Maryam passed her a clean cloth. "You can be sorry without deciding you are a terrible person."

"But I did something careless."

"Yes. One careless action. You can learn from it."

That distinction was small enough to miss and important enough to hold onto.

Al Zahraa whispered a personal prayer. "Allah, forgive my wrong choices. Help me be honest and more careful."

She knew a prayer did not replace saying sorry to Yusuf or respecting his things. She had already begun those parts, and she could keep doing them.

When the labels were sorted, she asked where to put the tray. Yusuf showed her a clear space away from the edge. She moved it with both hands.

Her apology was becoming something she did, not only something she said. She was glad Yusuf had given her time to show that.

Hamid needed a lens to inspect the small drawing of the gate latch. Al Zahraa's stomach tightened again when Yusuf opened the safe tray.

"Mine will not do," the clockmaker said. "But I have another way."

He brought out an older pair of strong reading glasses and a larger copy of the plan. They were slower to use, but they worked. The task would take longer because of the accident, and everyone adjusted.



Al Zahraa watched without demanding that they tell her it did not matter. It did matter. Yusuf's belongings mattered, and so did their time. She could face that truth while still treating herself kindly.

Nuri spread the notebook beside the enlarged drawing. The blocked stream and the stuck tower gate were now marked clearly. A third note mentioned the conservatory roof, which had loosened in the wind.

"Safiya's seedlings are under that roof," Maryam said.

Hamid frowned. "Then we must send help there before more rain arrives."

He arranged for another carpenter to meet Safiya, while Yusuf prepared the correct tools for the gate. No one could fix everything at once. They would need a careful order.

Al Zahraa pointed to a dotted line between the workshop and the tower. "Is that another path?"

Yusuf smiled. "Ask all the questions you need. That one is important."

The dotted line showed a low walkway along the hillside. The tower could be reached without going near the damaged bridge. Hamid would inspect it before taking the children farther. Yusuf would follow with the repair kit.



Al Zahraa wrote the plan neatly, leaving room for changes. She liked that a plan could be useful without pretending the future was certain.

As they prepared to leave, Yusuf handed her a wooden flower from the sorting tray.

"A bookmark," he explained. "You may keep it. I made these for visitors."

"Even after the lens?"

"The bookmark was for you before the lens broke."

She held it quietly. Forgiveness did not make the accident disappear. It made room for their friendship to continue beyond it.

At the door, she turned back. "I will remember to ask before touching tools."

"I believe you will try," Yusuf said.

That answer was gentle and realistic. She might make another mistake someday. She would still be able to tell the truth, seek forgiveness, and begin again.

Outside, the wind had freshened. The castle's pink flags stretched straight from their poles. Far ahead stood the Lantern Tower, tall and narrow against the sky.

Al Zahraa tucked the wooden flower beside Baba and Mama's letter. Both fitted inside her little bag. So did the brave, uncomfortable truth she had finally learned to carry.

Your Wonderland Challenge

Talk, draw, or write. Take your time.

I can tell the truth and make repairs.

1 NOTICE

What does Al Zahraa do immediately after the lens breaks? Which actions keep everyone safe?

2 THINK DEEPER

Why does telling the truth help even though it does not repair the glass or remove every consequence?

3 TRY ANOTHER VIEW

Imagine you are Yusuf. Write a response that is kind but still explains why his belongings must be respected.

4 CREATE

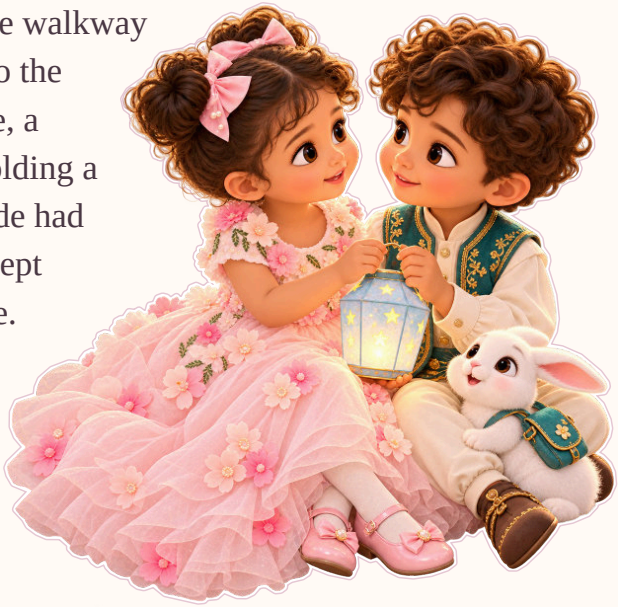
Make a four-step repair plan for a small mistake: tell the truth, apologise, ask how to help, and change an action.

5 LIVE IT

Practise a sincere apology without blaming someone else. You can use an imaginary situation instead of sharing a private one.

The Courage to Say No

Hamid checked the hillside walkway before leading the group to the Lantern Tower. At its base, a small boy sat on a step, holding a blue paper lantern. One side had folded in, and his thumb kept smoothing the same crease.



"I am Sami," he said when Al Zahraa introduced herself. "My family is new here. I made this for the gathering."

She sat beside him while Hamid inspected the tower door. The lantern was carefully made, but Sami looked as though he expected her to laugh at it.

"I like the little windows," Al Zahraa said.

Sami's shoulders loosened. He explained that he had planned to hang the lantern beside the other children's work. Then the wind had damaged the tower, and everyone seemed too busy to notice a newcomer.



"You can come with us," Al Zahraa offered. "We are helping the garden."

Sami looked at the locked tower door. "I know a quicker way inside. There is a side stair. The gate is only tied with string."

Hamid was speaking to the tower keeper a short distance away. Maryam was checking the notebook with Nuri. Sami stood up, eager to show something useful.

Al Zahraa wanted him to feel included. She also remembered the warning at the bridge.

"Has Hamid checked that stair?" she asked.

"It looks fine. We could get there first."

For a moment, being first sounded wonderful. They could surprise everyone. Sami would like her, and she would not have to be the smallest person waiting behind a rope.

Then she saw a loose stone on the stair's lowest step.

"No," she said. "I am not going up. We need to ask."

Sami's smile faded. "I thought you were brave."

The sentence hurt. Al Zahraa wished he had said almost anything else. She kept her feet where they were.

"I can be brave and stay here," she answered, though her voice shook. "You can stay with me. Let us show Hamid."

Sami frowned at his lantern. He did not want to look foolish in front of the carpenter. Al Zahraa understood that feeling very well after the broken lens.



She walked to Hamid and explained what they had found. She did not call Sami bad or try to make herself look clever. She simply described the stair and the loose stone.

Hamid thanked them and inspected the entrance. Behind the gate, several steps had shifted in the storm. He replaced the string with a proper barrier and a warning sign.

Sami became very quiet.

"I didn't know," he said.

"That is why we check," Hamid replied. "If you see an unsafe opening, tell us. We will make it secure."

Al Zahraa waited beside Sami without saying, "I told you so." She knew how those words could make a mistake feel like a public stage.

After a while, he muttered, "I am sorry I said you weren't brave."

"Thank you," she replied. "I still want you to come with us. But I will not go somewhere unsafe to prove I am your friend."

Sami nodded. The words were clear. They left the friendship open and the dangerous stair closed.

The tower keeper found a safe room on the ground floor where the children could wait. Its windows looked over the whole garden. From there, the dry channel resembled a pale ribbon winding among the flower beds.

Sami placed his lantern on the table. Al Zahraa asked whether he wanted help fixing the bent side.

"Yes, please."

Maryam showed them how to support the paper with a small cardboard strip. Al Zahraa held the lantern while Sami pressed the fold into place. It did not become perfectly smooth, but it stood upright.

"Would you like to hang it with ours tomorrow?" Maryam asked.

Sami smiled. There was still worry in the smile, but also room for hope.

Nuri opened his satchel and discovered that a pear had rolled onto the map. Everyone helped blot the damp patch. Al Zahraa laughed, then stopped when Nuri looked embarrassed.

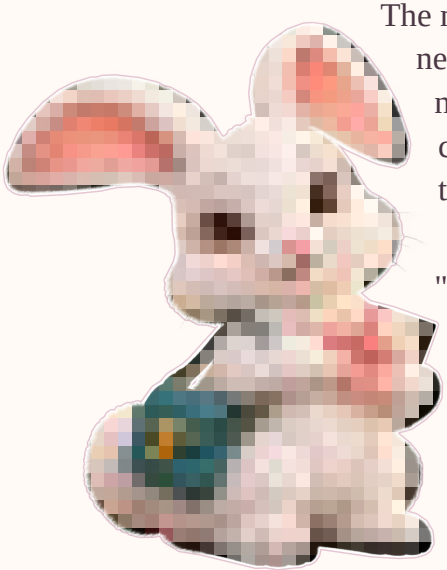
"Sorry," she said. "The surprise was funny. I am not laughing at you."

"Fair enough," Nuri said, rescuing the pear.

The little room was full of imperfect things: a creased lantern, a damp map, a repaired ribbon, and friends who sometimes chose the wrong words. None of these things prevented kindness. They simply gave kindness something real to do.

Al Zahraa looked towards the hills and quietly thanked Allah for people who helped her make safer choices.

Yusuf arrived with the repair kit. He and Hamid examined the water gate from the approved access door. The children watched only from the safe room while the adults worked.



The mechanism was jammed. A bent pin needed replacing, and the gate could not be opened until Huda's team had cleared the branches upstream. If they released water too soon, it might spill where workers were standing.

"So we wait for a message," Maryam said.

"Exactly," Yusuf answered. "A good repair includes knowing when not to act."

Al Zahraa liked that sentence. She wrote it beside her drawing of the warning sign.

Then a gust rattled the window. A grey curtain of rain was moving towards the valley. From below came the tower keeper's call: the conservatory needed more hands to move seedlings into its dry section.

Hamid checked the safe path to the conservatory. Yusuf would remain at the tower with another adult. Nuri would carry messages along the sheltered route.

Sami tucked the blue lantern under his arm. "May I come too?"

"We will ask the keeper to tell your family where you are," Hamid said. "Then you can help with the safe jobs."

Al Zahraa stood beside her new friend. She had feared that saying no would end their friendship before it began. Instead, they were leaving together, with a clearer idea of how to care for each other.

Your Wonderland Challenge

Talk, draw, or write. Take your time.

Kindness can have safe boundaries.

1 NOTICE

What makes the side stair unsafe? Why is "It looks fine" not enough information?

2 THINK DEEPER

Explain how Al Zahraa protects both her boundary and her friendship with Sami.

3 TRY ANOTHER VIEW

Rewrite "I thought you were brave" as a respectful response to a friend's refusal.

4 CREATE

Make a short dialogue using these ideas: "No, I am not comfortable," "Let us ask," and "We can choose another way."

5 LIVE IT

Name two trusted adults you could approach with a concern. You never need to share a personal secret to complete this page.

The Night of Rain and Lanterns



Rain reached the conservatory just as they stepped inside. It tapped the glass in tiny silver fingers, then drummed harder. A roof panel had loosened above the far benches. Hamid's fellow carpenter was already securing the area, while Safiya guided everyone towards the sheltered side.

"Small pots only for the children," she said. "Stay on the dry floor. Leave the heavy trays to us."

Al Zahraa picked up one seedling with both hands. The little plant trembled with each step. She wondered whether it was frightened too.

They carried the pots in a careful line. Maryam checked labels, Sami cleared a low shelf, and Al Zahraa placed each plant where Safiya pointed. Nuri darted between the adults with messages, his satchel protected beneath a folded cloth.



The work was useful, but there seemed to be so much of it. Every empty space filled immediately. Every quiet moment ended with another crash of thunder.

Al Zahraa's arms grew tired. She nearly picked up another pot anyway. If she stopped, perhaps the others would think she did not care enough.

Safiya noticed her slowing steps. "Your turn to rest."

"But there are more."

"There are also more people. Put that one down, and come sit with me."

They sat on a bench where the rain could not reach them. Safiya wrapped a dry shawl around Al Zahraa's shoulders. The princess was surprised by how close she had been to tears.

"I wanted to save every flower," she said.

"We will care for as many as we can," Safiya replied. "You are not responsible for the whole storm."

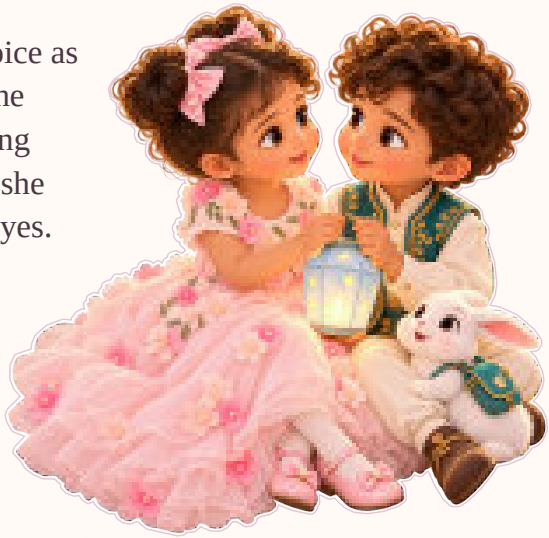
Al Zahraa leaned against the cushion. Her feet throbbed inside her pretty shoes. She missed Mama's lap and Baba's familiar voice.

She loved Wonderland. She also wanted home. Both feelings sat beside her, as real as the rain on the glass.

A loud thunderclap made Al Zahraa jump. Sami sat down nearby, hugging the blue lantern against his chest.

"I don't like that sound," he admitted.

"Neither do I," she said.



They listened to Safiya's calm voice as she explained that they were in the sheltered room with adults keeping watch. Al Zahraa asked whether she could hold her hand. Safiya said yes.

The princess whispered, "Allah, please protect us. Give us calm hearts and help us care for one another."

The rain did not stop because she had finished speaking. She still felt uneasy. But she had put her worry into words, and she was no longer carrying it silently.

Safiya offered water and a small piece of bread. Al Zahraa took a slow sip. She named three things she could see: a golden lamp, Sami's blue lantern, and a leaf shaped like a heart. The room felt less enormous after that.

Sami asked whether being scared meant he had failed at being brave.

"I don't think so," Al Zahraa answered. "I was scared when I said no at the stair."

He smiled a little. "That was brave."

She looked towards the rain. Perhaps courage could sit on a bench, wrapped in a shawl, holding someone's hand. It did not always need to be running towards the next job.

When Al Zahraa felt ready, she asked for a seated task. Safiya brought a basket of labels that needed drying. The children spread them on cloths and matched them to the names in the notebook.

One seed tray had tipped before the workers reached it. Some seedlings could be replanted; others were too damaged. Al Zahraa watched Safiya set the damaged ones aside.



"Will those grow again?" she asked.

"These ones will not," the gardener replied gently. "We can sow new seeds later. I am sad about them too."

Al Zahraa had expected an answer that made everything better immediately. Instead, she received the truth and someone to feel sad with.

They did not throw away the labels. Safiya placed them in an envelope marked for the next planting. Something had been lost, and something could still begin again.

Later, the princess opened a new page in the notebook. She wrote the things she was thankful for: shelter, clean water, kind hands, and the chance to try again. Below them, she wrote, "I am sad about the seedlings."

The two lists did not cancel each other.

"Alhamdulillah for what we have," she whispered. She could love Allah and be honest about a difficult day. Her sadness did not have to hide outside the door before she prayed.

By evening, the hardest rain had passed. The adults had secured the roof, and the dry benches were crowded with rescued pots. Safiya counted the children, checked that Sami's family knew where he was, and arranged warm food for everyone.

Nuri returned with a message from the tower. Yusuf had replaced the bent pin. Huda's team would inspect the upstream blockage in the morning, when they could work safely in daylight.

The gathering would begin later than planned. Some flower beds would still look bare. There would be no perfect ending tied neatly with a ribbon by bedtime.

Al Zahraa was too tired to argue with that anymore.

She and Sami set their paper lanterns on the table while Maryam hung a battery lamp behind them. Blue and pink light spread across the wall. The room looked like a small piece of the sky had come indoors.

Safiya brought blankets to the resting room next door, where trusted adults would remain nearby. Al Zahraa took Baba and Mama's letter from her bag and read it again.

"On joyful days and difficult days, when you feel brave and when you need to be held, our love will stay."

She pressed the page gently against her cheek.

Outside, rain slid from the leaves. Inside, her eyes grew heavy. She fell asleep within her dream, with her own small lantern still glowing beside the others.

Your Wonderland Challenge

Talk, draw, or write. Take your time.

I can feel deeply and still find hope.

1 NOTICE

What signs show that Al Zahraa needs rest? How does Safiya respond?

2 THINK DEEPER

Explain why gratitude does not require Al Zahraa to pretend that the lost seedlings do not matter.

3 TRY ANOTHER VIEW

Sami thinks fear means failure. Use two moments from the story to offer him a different view.

4 CREATE

Divide a page into "What feels hard" and "What helps." Draw or write one thing in each space.

5 LIVE IT

Plan a gentle rest routine with a trusted adult: a quiet place, water, a comforting activity, and a personal dua if you wish.

The Morning We Worked Together



Morning arrived quietly. Pale light touched the conservatory windows, and drops of rain shone along the frames. Al Zahraa woke beneath the soft shawl and heard Safiya speaking to Huda by the door.

The upstream team had inspected the channel. The branches could be removed safely. Yusuf's replacement pin was ready. At last, the repairs could be joined into one plan.

Al Zahraa reached for her notebook. Then she stopped to drink the water beside her bed.

Today, she would not forget that the helper needed care too.

The adults gathered around a table while the children listened. Huda's team would clear the upstream obstruction. Hamid would reinforce the damaged channel wall. Yusuf would open the tower gate only after both teams reported that their work areas were clear.



Safiya would watch the first flower beds for leaks or overflow. Nuri would carry written messages along the approved paths. Every message would say who had sent it and what had been checked.

"What can we do?" Al Zahraa asked.

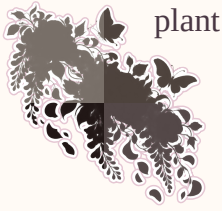
"Help me prepare the garden," Safiya said. "We need to move the empty watering bowls and mark the beds that still require hand watering."

The princess had secretly hoped to turn the great gate herself. She felt the little sting of disappointment, recognised it, and let it pass without pretending it was not there.

"Can I keep track of the beds?"

"That would help a great deal."

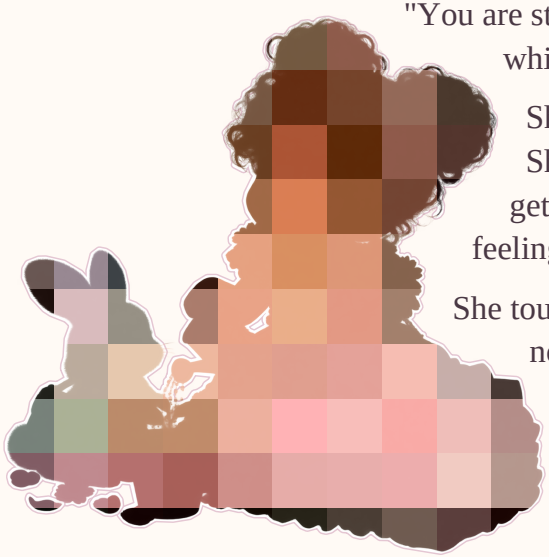
Maryam checked the labels. Sami drew simple symbols beside the plant names so younger visitors could understand them. Al Zahraa marked each bed in the notebook.



Their work was quiet. It would not be the moment everyone cheered about. Yet if they forgot a fragile plant, that plant would still be thirsty after the main channel filled.

She began to understand that useful work did not always stand in the brightest part of the picture.

At the first bed, Al Zahraa found the little seedling she had moved on the day she arrived. Safiya had placed it in a new pot. One leaf was still bent, but another had lifted towards the morning light.



"You are still here," the princess whispered.

She did not mean only the plant. She was still here too, after getting lost, making a mistake, feeling afraid, and needing a rest.

She touched the earth beside the pot, not the tender stem. The soil smelled clean after the rain. A bird called from the wall, and a butterfly settled near the pale flowers.

Al Zahraa felt love for Allah rise quietly within her gratitude: for life, for the people who cared for her, for the chance to learn and begin again. She did not need Wonderland's castle to remember that love. A small leaf was enough to remind her.

"Allah, help me care for what You have given me," she prayed in her own words.

Then she asked Safiya how much water the seedling needed. Loving the garden included learning how to care for it properly.

Nearby, Sami struggled to lift a watering bowl. Al Zahraa did not tell him to try harder. She called Maryam, and the three carried it together after Safiya checked that it was light enough.

The bowl moved. Nobody had needed to be the strongest person in the garden.

The first message arrived before noon: the upstream branches were clear, but Hamid needed more time to secure the wall. Yusuf kept the gate closed.

Al Zahraa waited by the little waterwheel. She could picture water rushing down the channel. She wanted to hear its paddles turn. Minutes passed, and it remained perfectly still.

"Perhaps they forgot," Sami said.

"Let us ask Safiya before guessing," Al Zahraa answered.

Safiya checked the message and explained the delay. A loose stone needed replacing. The workers had found it because they had taken time to inspect the wall carefully.

Maryam suggested they use the wait to finish the last bed labels. Al Zahraa agreed. She was beginning to recognise a useful question: What can I do here, with the information I have now?

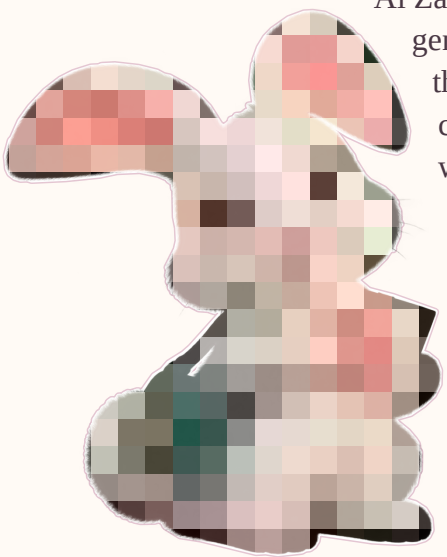
At last, Nuri returned with a second written message. Both work areas were clear. The repaired wall had been checked. Yusuf could begin opening the gate slowly.

Safiya gathered the children behind the garden boundary line, where they could watch safely. Al Zahraa held Sami's hand with his permission. Maryam stood beside them, the notebook tucked beneath her arm.

From the tower came the faint sound of gears turning. Then there was a pause.

A thin silver thread of water appeared at the far end of the channel. It slipped around the first bend and disappeared behind the roses.

The water returned into view, running slowly over the pale stones. It reached the little wheel, pushed one paddle, and stopped. A leaf was caught against its side.



Al Zahraa almost rushed forward. Safiya gently reminded everyone to stay behind the line. She called a worker, who checked the flow and removed the leaf with the proper tool.

The wheel turned once. Then again. Its small wooden paddles made a cheerful clicking sound.

Everyone cheered.

Al Zahraa laughed so hard that she nearly cried. The garden was not fully restored. One bed remained bare, and hand watering was still needed in the far corner. But water was moving where it had been absent. Real progress did not have to be complete to be worth celebrating.

"Alhamdulillah," she said, full of relief.

Safiya thanked the workers by name. Hamid thanked Huda. Yusuf thanked the people who had carried messages. Maryam pointed to Sami's clear labels, and Sami pointed to Al Zahraa's notebook.

Nobody had done the whole thing alone.

When someone called Al Zahraa a wonderful helper, she smiled. She could enjoy the praise without needing it to hold her together. The letter in her bag had been true before the waterwheel moved.

Across the path, the Garden of First Light was preparing for its gathering. The paper lanterns were a little wrinkled, the flowers uneven, and the tables full of welcome.

Your Wonderland Challenge

Talk, draw, or write. Take your time.

I can help without carrying everything alone.

1 NOTICE

Why must Yusuf wait for two teams to report before opening the gate? Explain the order of the plan.

2 THINK DEEPER

Which quiet task matters most to you in this chapter? Explain why useful work can be easy to overlook.

3 TRY ANOTHER VIEW

What would you say to someone who claims Al Zahraa saved the whole garden by herself?

4 CREATE

Draw a chain of helpers. Label at least four people and the different contributions they make.

5 LIVE IT

Thank someone whose work often goes unnoticed. Include exactly what they did and how it helped you.

The Princess Who Came Home



By afternoon, the garden smelled of warm bread, wet leaves, and roses. Lanterns hung at different heights because their makers were different heights. Sami's blue lantern stood beside a pink one, its repaired fold turned proudly towards the path.

Al Zahraa looked down at her dress. There was a little earth on the hem. Her bow had slipped, and the ribbon on her bag was tied in an uneven knot.

She had imagined arriving at a celebration looking perfect.

Instead, she arrived looking like someone who had lived a story.

Safiya welcomed everyone, including people who had been unable to help with the repairs. Some had been ill. Some had been caring for family. Others had arrived only that morning.

There were chairs for all of them.



Al Zahraa noticed this before she noticed the flowers on the table. Wonderland had not become a place where only useful people were allowed to eat cake.

Sami found his family near the conservatory and hurried to show them his lantern. Maryam displayed the small bridge model beside a drawing of the real repairs. Hamid laughed when Nuri suggested naming the model "The Bridge That Stayed Out of the Soup."

Yusuf came carrying a tray of wooden bookmarks. His damaged lens was safely put away for repair. He handed each visitor a flower, a leaf, or a star.

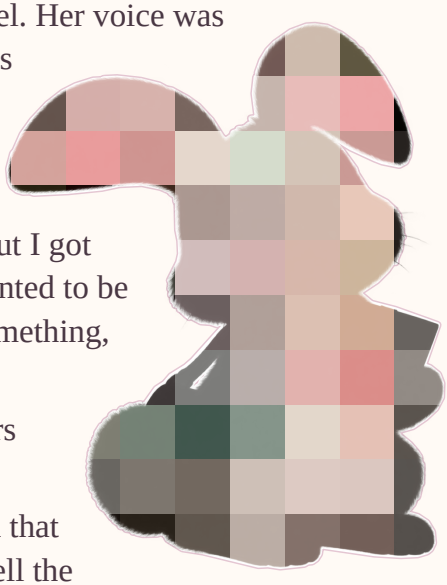
When Al Zahraa thanked him, she did not ask again whether he was angry. She had apologised, helped where she could, and changed how she behaved around his tools. Their friendship could move forward.

She watched the people sharing food and felt a deep, warm happiness. It was different from the sharp wish to be the most special person in a room.

She was special to the people who loved her. Other people were precious too. There was room for all of them beneath the lanterns.

After the meal, Safiya invited anyone who wished to speak about the journey. Al Zahraa's hand lifted before she had time to become completely certain.

She stood beside the little waterwheel. Her voice was quiet at first. Maryam turned towards her, and the others followed. They made a space for listening.



"I thought being a princess meant knowing what to do," she began. "But I got things wrong. I was frightened. I wanted to be better than someone else. I broke something, and I needed a rest."

Nuri nodded so seriously that his ears bounced.

"I learned to ask questions. I learned that saying no can be kind. I learned to tell the truth, even when I wished I didn't have to. And I learned that I can love Allah, ask for help, and take the next careful step."

She looked at her friends.

"Thank you for helping me."

There was a warm burst of applause. Al Zahraa enjoyed it. Then it ended, and she was still herself.

Safiya invited Sami to speak next, but he shook his head. "Maybe another time."

"That is all right," she said.

Al Zahraa moved over to make room for him on the bench. She did not tell him he had to be brave in exactly the way she had been brave. His next step could look different.

As the afternoon softened, Nuri brought Al Zahraa an envelope. Inside was a drawing of the garden made by all her friends. Maryam had drawn the repaired channel, Sami the lanterns, and Safiya the little seedling. Nuri had drawn himself much larger than everyone else, apparently by accident.



On the back, they had written, "You have a place with us."

Al Zahraa held it carefully. "I think it is time for me to go home."

Nobody asked her to stay because there was more work to do. There would always be more work: beds to plant, a lens to mend, and a bridge to rebuild. Leaving did not mean she had stopped caring.

Safiya walked with her to the rose-covered door. The gardener gave her a gentle hug after asking whether she would like one. Al Zahraa did.

"Will I remember everything?" the princess asked.

"Not all at once," Safiya replied. "That is what stories and kind reminders are for."

Al Zahraa thanked Allah for the friends in her dream and for the family waiting beyond it. The door opened onto a soft purple light.

She took one last look at the garden. The little waterwheel was turning, but even if it stopped tomorrow, the friendships would still need tending. She understood that now.

Then the scent of roses faded into the familiar warmth of her own pillow.

Al Zahraa opened her eyes. The star lamp stood beside the bed. Her purple rabbit pyjamas were wrinkled at the knees. Somewhere nearby, Baba was asking whether anyone had seen his glasses. Mama laughed and said they were on his head.

Home.



She hurried into Mama's arms and began telling the story in a tumble of words: a rabbit, a bridge, a broken lens, a storm, a little wheel.

"That sounds like a very big adventure," Baba said.

Al Zahraa became quiet. "Would you love me if I couldn't fix the garden?"

"Yes," Mama answered.

"If I made a mistake?"

"Yes," Baba said. "We would help you face it and make things right. Our love would stay."

Al Zahraa rested against them. She did not need another question just then.

Later, she said "Alhamdulillah" for the new morning. She made a little dua for her family and for a heart that loved Allah and treated people gently. Then she helped water a plant, with Baba showing her how much it needed.

A little water spilled onto the floor.

For one second, she frowned. Then she fetched a cloth.

"I can try again," she said.

Outside, the day was beginning. There was no castle beyond the window, but there was a world to notice, good work to share, and love that had been waiting for her all along.

Your Wonderland Challenge

Talk, draw, or write. Take your time.

Love stays with me wherever I grow.

1 NOTICE

Who is welcomed at the gathering even without helping with the repairs? Why is this detail important?

2 THINK DEEPER

How has Al Zahraa's idea of being a princess changed since Chapter 1? Use two examples from her journey.

3 TRY ANOTHER VIEW

Sami chooses not to speak. Why is accepting his choice part of a kind and confident friendship?

4 CREATE

Write a new scene in which Al Zahraa faces an everyday difficulty at home and uses something she learned in Wonderland.

5 LIVE IT

Choose one lesson to practise this week. Tell someone you trust how they can encourage you without expecting perfection.

For the girl you will become

Dear Al Zahraa,

There will be days when you feel certain and days when you need someone to remind you of your strength. Both kinds of days belong in a good life.



You may be proud of your gifts without being better than anyone else. You may ask for help without being less capable. You may make a mistake and still deserve patience, guidance, and care.

Let your love of Allah make room in your days for gratitude, prayer, honesty, and kindness. When something is difficult, speak to Him in your own words and reach for the trusted people who can help you.

Keep learning. Protect your voice. Offer yourself the gentleness you would give a small, growing flower. You do not need to rush into someone else's shape.

And remember the words that opened this story: you never have to earn your parents' love. There is a place for you in their hearts on every page of your life.

Words for a faithful heart

Bismillah	In the name of Allah. A loving way to begin.
Alhamdulillah	All praise is for Allah. Words of gratitude.
Dua	Calling upon Allah and asking Him for help.
Sabr	Patience and perseverance through difficulty.
Tawakkul	Trust in Allah while taking responsible steps.

A PERSONAL DUA

Allah, fill my heart with love for You. Thank You for my family and the people who care for me. Help me speak truthfully, learn patiently, and treat myself and others with kindness. When I am afraid, help me ask for support and choose a safe next step. Guide me towards what is good, and help me begin again after mistakes. Ameen.

This is an original personal prayer for the story, not a quotation from the Quran or hadith.

Read together and wonder

The challenges are invitations to think, not a test of how good or brave a child is. Accept spoken answers, pictures, acting, or quiet reflection. A child may skip a personal question and discuss the characters instead.

CONVERSATION STARTERS

1-2 Belonging

Ask what makes love different from a prize, and how friends can have different strengths.

3-4 Voice and learning

Notice both the speaker and the listener. Praise safe choices, honest questions, and practice.

5-6 Patience and repair

Explore how feelings can coexist. Separate a mistaken action from the worth of the person.

7-8 Safety and comfort

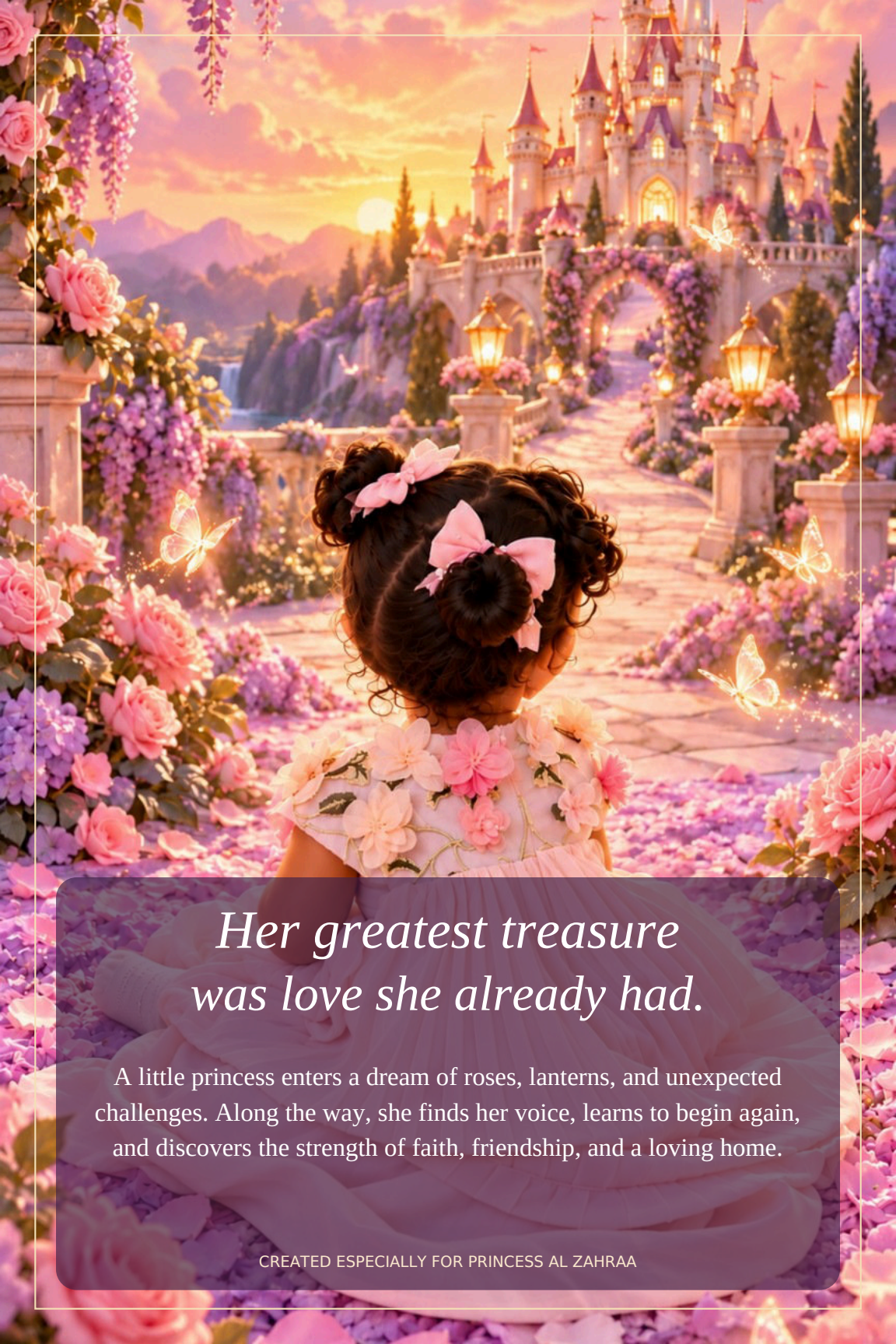
Practise a kind refusal. Let asking for help, resting, and expressing sadness count as strengths.

9-10 Shared courage

Name the many helpers. Remember that welcome is for people who could not contribute too.

OUR FAMILY REMINDER

One sentence we want Al Zahraa to hear often:



Her greatest treasure was love she already had.

A little princess enters a dream of roses, lanterns, and unexpected challenges. Along the way, she finds her voice, learns to begin again, and discovers the strength of faith, friendship, and a loving home.

CREATED ESPECIALLY FOR PRINCESS AL ZAHRAA